

Airpower over South Vietnam

American airpower was highly effective, in terms of supporting troops in the field, minimizing US casualties, and delivering injured people—sometimes including Vietnamese civilians and enemy combatants—to safety.

◀◀ BEFORE

While the Viet Cong ruled the jungle of South Vietnam, US forces dominated the skies.

NEW PHASE

As **Operation Rolling Thunder** intensified in the skies over North Vietnam, more ground troops were required in the South to **provide security for American bases**.

SUPPORTING OPERATIONS

The success of operations such as **Cedar Falls** depended on air support to bomb Viet Cong forces flushed into the open by US ground troops.

As American troop levels climbed over the course of 1965, and the US began to engage in offensive rather than defensive operations, more airpower was needed to support and protect these ground troops, deepening American investment in the war.

Supplying the troops

The vast majority of the millions of fixed-wing and helicopter sorties flown over South Vietnam were for flying cargo, known in the war's vernacular as trash hauling. Some of the crews flew a set schedule each day, making regular deliveries or providing a shuttle service on a predictable route. Others flew ad hoc supply missions that often took them into treacherous weather conditions or onto dangerous runways.

Helicopter pilots often struggled to identify landing zones (LZs) from the air, especially in remote areas. They relied on radar guidance, nearby features in the landscape, and smoke grenades released by troops on the ground. To ensure the grenades were not released by enemy combatants seeking to lure the pilot into a trap, the smoke was color coded.

Hauling cargo in South Vietnam might mean delivering hot meals to exhausted GIs on patrol in the jungle, or water and ammunition to a landing zone under fire, or perhaps flying a Conex ("container express") shipping crate of consumer goods, suspended in a net that could be easily dropped, to a mountaintop firebase. It could also mean flying combat troops into action, collecting the wounded and delivering them to hospitals, or removing the dead from the battlefield, a traumatic process that brought crews insulated to some degree by altitude directly into contact with the shooting war on the ground.

Whatever the mission, many US and ARVN Air Force aircraft risked small arms fire when taking off, landing, or flying just above treetops. Along the Ho Chi Minh Trail and in other hotspots along American bombing routes, airmen also faced anti-aircraft artillery from the NVA and Viet Cong.